



Welcome to the Valley

A Curated First-Time Player Experience

2026-07-20

1 01 — Setup: Installing SMAPI and Mod Organizer 2

This chapter walks through setting up Mod Organizer 2 (MO2) and SMAPI, the two tools you need to manage and run Stardew Valley mods. Follow every step in order — skipping ahead is where things break.

1.1 Prerequisites

- **Stardew Valley 1.6.15** (or latest) installed via Steam or GOG. Run it once before modding so the game generates its initial config files.
- **~2 GB free disk space** for the modlist.
- A free [Nexus Mods](#) account — almost every mod in this catalog is hosted there.

1.2 How This Guide Is Structured: The Three-Wave Approach

This guide teaches Stardew Valley in three waves. Each wave adds complexity — install each wave's mods as a group, play with them until you're comfortable, then move on. Installing everything at once will overwhelm you with mechanics you have no context for.

1.2.1 Wave 1 — Vanilla (Enhanced Quality of Life)

Play your first year (or more) with only **foundations, bugfixes, and UI/HUD mods** installed. The game looks cleaner, runs smoother, and surfaces information better — but every mechanic is pure Stardew Valley. Chapter [02-vanilla-primer.md](#) teaches all the core systems: farming, mining, fishing, combat, relationships, and the Community Center.

Wave 1 mod catalog sections: [00 — Foundations](#) · [01 — Bugfixes](#) · [02 — UI and HUD](#)

1.2.2 Wave 2 — Content Expansion

Once vanilla mechanics are second nature, add content mods. These introduce new areas, items, enemies, NPCs, and storylines — but the core game loop (farm → mine → craft → build relationships → repeat) stays intact. Chapter [04-modded-gameplay.md](#) section “Wave 2” teaches the new systems these mods bring.

Wave 2 mod catalog sections: [03–06 — Graphics](#) · [07 — World Expansion](#) · [08 — Monsters and Combat](#) · [09 — Items and Weapons](#) · [10 — NPC Interactions](#) · [11 — Grown-Up Town](#) · [15 — Music and Audio](#)

1.2.3 Wave 3 — Gameplay Overhaul

For players who have thoroughly explored Waves 1 and 2 and want deeper mechanical changes. These mods rework skill trees, profession paths, farming systems, and core gameplay balance. They assume you know the game intimately — rebalancing mods won't make sense if you don't know what they changed.

Wave 3 mod catalog sections: [12 — Gameplay Tweaks](#) · [13 — Skills and Professions](#) · [14 — Farming and Making](#)

1.3 Installing SMAPI

SMAPI (Stardew Modding API) is the loader that lets mods hook into the game. Without it, no mod works.

1. Go to smapi.io and download the installer for Windows.
2. Run the installer. It will ask where Stardew Valley is installed:
 - **Steam:** `C:\Program Files (x86)\Steam\steamapps\common\Stardew Valley`
 - **GOG:** `C:\Program Files (x86)\GOG Galaxy\Games\Stardew Valley`
 - **Game Pass:** The WindowsApps folder — use the “find my game” button in the installer.
3. The installer patches `StardewModdingAPI.exe` into your game folder and adds a “play with SMAPI” option to your Steam/GOG launcher.

To verify: run the game via SMAPI. You should see a dark console window open alongside the game with SMAPI version info. If you see that, SMAPI is working.

Do not install mods yet — MO2 will handle that.

1.4 Installing Mod Organizer 2

MO2 keeps your Stardew Valley install folder clean by virtualising the mod file system. Every mod lives in its own directory inside MO2 — nothing touches the game folder directly.

1. Download the latest release from the [MO2 GitHub releases page](#).
2. Run the installer. Choose **Portable** when asked — this keeps all mod data inside a single folder (recommended for modlists).
3. Pick an install location outside `Program Files` to avoid permission issues. Example: `C:\Games\Mod Organizer 2`.
4. When the installer asks which game to manage, select **Stardew Valley** (or skip and set it up manually later).

1.4.1 First Launch

1. Launch MO2. It will open a setup wizard asking for the Stardew Valley executable location. Point it to your game folder.
2. MO2 will ask about Nexus integration. Log in with your Nexus Mods account — this enables “Download with Mod Manager” buttons on Nexus mod pages.
3. You should see the main MO2 window. On the right sidebar, confirm the game is detected as **Stardew Valley**.

1.5 Configuring MO2 for This Modlist

1.5.1 Create a Profile

1. In the top toolbar, click **Profile** (dropdown) → **<Manage...>**.
2. Create a new profile called `SDV ModList Guide`. Check “Use profile-specific Game INI Files” — this keeps our tweaks separate from vanilla.
3. Set this profile as default.

1.5.2 Add SMAPI as an Executable

1. In MO2, click the **Executables** dropdown (top-right, shows “Stardew Valley” by default) → **<Edit...>**.
2. Click the + → **Add from file...** → navigate to your Stardew Valley folder and select `StardewModdingAPI.exe`.
3. Name it **SMAPI** and click **OK**.
4. Select **SMAPI** from the executables dropdown — this is what you will always launch through from now on.

1.5.3 Set Up Separators

Separators are visual dividers in MO2’s left panel that keep your load order organised. This guide uses 15 category separators matching the mod catalog chapters. Create them now (or after installing mods):

1. In the left panel, right-click the empty space → **Create separator**.
2. Name it after the mod category (e.g., `=== 01 - Bugfixes ===`).
3. Repeat for all 15 categories listed in [05-mo2-separators.md](#).

Separators don’t affect load order — they just keep your list readable.

1.6 Installing Mods

The mod catalog in [03-mod-catalog/](#) lists every mod in installation order. Each category should be installed as a group before moving to the next.

1.6.1 Downloading from Nexus Mods

- Browse to the mod’s Nexus page and click **Download with**

Manager. MO2 will pick it up automatically.

- If the download doesn't start, check that MO2's Nexus integration is logged in (Tools → Settings → Nexus).

1.6.2 Installing in MO2

1. In MO2's right panel, double-click the downloaded archive (or select it and click the install icon).
2. MO2 shows a preview of the mod's file structure. Click **OK**.
3. A dialog may warn about overwriting files — click **Replace** only if you are sure the new mod should override. When in doubt, check the mod catalog notes.

1.6.3 Load Order (Left Panel) vs Plugin Order (Right Panel)

- **Left panel** (mod list): Determines which mod's files win when two mods modify the same game file. Higher = wins.
- **Right panel** (plugins/Content Patcher): Controls SMAPI load order. Higher = loads later, overrides earlier plugins.

For this modlist, the left panel order is what matters most. The mod catalog tells you exactly where each mod should sit.

1.7 Verifying Your Installation

Before diving in, run a quick sanity check:

1. In MO2, select the **SMAPI** executable and click **Run**.
2. The SMAPI console opens and shows each mod being loaded. Watch for red **ERROR** or yellow **WARN** lines — they indicate broken dependencies or version mismatches.
3. Once the game reaches the title screen, quit. If SMAPI showed no errors, your setup is good.

1.7.1 Common Issues

Problem	Fix
"SMAPI not found" or game launches without console	Re-run the SMAPI installer
MO2 says game executable not found	Check MO2's executable settings point to Stardew Valley.exe in your game folder
Mod has a red X (missing DLL)	You missed a required dependency — check the mod catalog entry
Mod downloads won't start in MO2	Re-authenticate Nexus integration in MO2 settings

Problem	Fix
Game crashes on launch	Disable all mods and enable them one category at a time

1.8 Next Steps

With SMAPI and MO2 ready, move to [02-vanilla-primer.md](#) for a crash course on playing Stardew Valley. If you already know the basics, jump straight into the mod catalog starting with [01-bugfixes.md](#).

2 02 — Vanilla Primer: How to Play Stardew Valley

This chapter covers everything a first-time player needs to know to play Stardew Valley comfortably. The mod catalog later assumes you understand these basics, so read through even if you think you know the game — some 1.6 mechanics may be new to you.

2.1 Welcome to the Valley

Stardew Valley is a farming/life simulation RPG. You inherit your grandfather's overgrown farm in a small town called Pelican Town. What you do with it is up to you: grow crops, raise animals, mine for ore, befriend the locals, fight monsters, fish, cook, craft, and more. There is no wrong way to play, and there is no time limit — the story progresses at your pace.

The core loop: **use energy to do things** → **earn money** → **buy upgrades** → **unlock new things to do** → **repeat**.

2.2 Character Creation

When you start a new game, you choose:

- **Appearance, name, farm name, and favourite thing.** Favourite thing has a small effect on a late-game event — pick something funny.
- **Farm type.** This determines your farm map layout and gives a bonus to a specific skill:
 - **Standard Farm** — Largest open space. Best for new players.
 - **Riverland Farm** — Islands separated by water. Boosts fishing.
 - **Forest Farm** — Plenty of forage and hardwood stumps that regrow. Boosts foraging.

- **Hill-Top Farm** — A quarry spawns on the farm. Boosts mining.
- **Wilderness Farm** — Monsters appear at night. Boosts combat.
- **Four Corners Farm** — Split into four themed quadrants. Designed for co-op, but fine solo.
- **Beach Farm** — Large but sprinklers don't work on sand. Boosts fishing and foraging.
- **Meadowlands Farm (1.6)** — Starts with a chicken coop and two chickens. Boosts farming.

Recommendation for first-timers: Standard Farm or Meadowlands Farm. The others add restrictions that make early-game harder.

2.3 The First Day

You arrive at Pelican Town on Spring 1, Year 1. Mayor Lewis greets you, gives you a brief tour, and leaves you at your overgrown farm. You have a small cabin, a few parsnip seeds, and 500 gold.

Do this on day 1:

1. Open your inventory and equip the hoe (right-click or X to place in your hands).
2. Hoe 15 tiles of dirt in front of your cabin.
3. Plant the 15 parsnip seeds and water them with your watering can.
4. Walk south into town and introduce yourself. You can explore until 2:00 AM — don't stay up past that or you'll pass out and lose money.

2.4 Understanding the Basics

2.4.1 Energy and Time

Your energy bar (lightning bolt icon, bottom-right) depletes as you use tools. If it hits zero, you move slowly and can't use tools. Eating food restores energy.

The day runs from 6:00 AM to 2:00 AM. **Go to bed before 2:00 AM** or you collapse and lose up to 10% of your gold (capped at 1,000g). Going to bed early is fine — waking up at 6:00 AM is automatic regardless of when you sleep.

The game saves when you sleep. There is no manual save.

2.4.2 Tools

You start with five tools:

Tool	Use	Upgrade
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Tool	Use	Upgrade
Hoe	Till soil for planting, dig up artifact spots	Hoe more tiles at once
Watering Can	Water crops	Water more tiles at once
Pickaxe	Break rocks, mine ore	Break rocks faster
Axe	Chop wood, clear stumps/logs	Chop faster, fell big stumps
Sword	Fight monsters in the mines (you get it on day 5)	Higher damage

Upgrade tools at Clint the blacksmith's shop by paying gold + ore. You must have the previous tier before upgrading to the next. Higher tiers let you charge your tool to affect more tiles (hoe/watering can) or break tougher objects (pickaxe/axe).

2.4.3 Skills

Every activity levels up a corresponding skill. Each skill has 10 levels. Every 5 levels you choose a **profession** — a permanent perk.

Skill	How to Level	Key Benefit
Farming	Harvest crops, pet animals	More produce, less energy use
Mining	Break rocks in the mines	More ore, gem rewards
Foraging	Pick up foraged items, chop wood	More items from wild plants
Fishing	Catch fish	Easier fishing minigame
Combat	Kill monsters in the mines	More damage, better loot

2.5 Skills in Detail

2.5.1 Farming

The main money-maker. Clear some land, hoe it, plant seeds, water daily, harvest when ready. Water is the limiting factor early on — you can only water about 60–80 tiles before running out of energy.

Crop rules:

- Every crop has a **growth time** (in days) listed on the seed packet.
- Each season is 28 days. Seasonal crops die when the season changes.
- **Deadline:** If a seed packet says “8 days to grow”, plant it by Spring 21 at the latest to harvest before Summer.
- Crops need water every day except on rainy days — the game waters

them for you.

- **Sprinklers** (unlocked at Farming level 2) automate watering. They are your top priority milestone.

Animals unlock later with barns and coops. Animals produce daily (milk, eggs, wool) and need petting for max happiness.

2.5.2 Mining

The mines are in the northeast, accessed via the mountain path. Enter any time after day 5 when you receive a letter from the Adventurer's Guild.

- 120 floors, each procedurally generated.
- **Elevator** every 5 floors — use it to skip back to your deepest floor.
- Break rocks for stone, coal, copper, iron, gold, and gems.
- Every 10 floors, the ore tier changes: Copper (1–39), Iron (40–79), Gold (80–119), Iridium (120).
- **Combat tip:** Take food, watch your health, and don't chase bats into crowds. The elevator is your safety net — leave before you die.
- Deeper floors have better ore. Prioritise reaching floor 80+ for consistent gold ore.

2.5.3 Foraging

Wild plants, berries, and tree seeds spawn across the map. Pick up everything you see. Foraging levels unlock:

- Level 1: Spring onions in the forest south of town
- Level 4: Salmonberries (Spring 15–18) and Blackberries (Fall 8–11) — these bush fruits are great early food
- Level 7: Winter roots and yams can be found by tilling dirt

Tapping trees (level 3) lets you place tappers for oak resin, maple syrup, and pine tar — essential for mid-game crafting.

2.5.4 Fishing

The most challenging skill early on. The fishing minigame has a green bar that you control. Fish move up and down; you keep the bar behind them to fill the progress meter.

- **Tackle** and **bait** make it easier. The Training Rod (buy from Willy) has a larger green bar for beginners.
- Each body of water (ocean, lake, river) has different fish.
- Fish sell for decent money. Fishing in the ocean or mountain lake is most profitable early on.
- **Crab pots** (level 3) are passive income — place them in water, check daily.

2.5.5 Combat

Fighting takes place in the mines. You get a starter sword from the Adventurer's Guild on day 5.

- **Sword:** Balanced — block with right-click.
- **Club:** Slow but high knockback.
- **Dagger:** Fast but short range.

Kill slimes, bugs, skeletons, and flying serpents. They drop loot you can sell or use for crafting. Levels 5 and 10 let you choose between a fighter and scout path — fighter is better on a first playthrough.

2.6 Money Making

Early game, you need gold for seeds, tool upgrades, and backpack expansion. Best sources in order:

1. **Fishing** — 300–500g per day if you're decent at the minigame.
2. **Crops** — Parsnips are cheap and fast; potatoes and cauliflower scale better. Once you can craft Quality Sprinklers (Farming level 6), farming becomes your main income.
3. **Foraging** — Free money. Spring onions (south of Marnie's ranch) sell for 40g each.
4. **Artisan goods** — Put crops in kegs (Farming level 8) and preserves jars (Farming level 4) for 2–3x the crop value.

Priority purchases:

1. Backpack upgrade (2,000g at Pierre's) — triples inventory space. Buy it day 2 or 3.
2. Copper watering can upgrade (2,000g + 5 copper bars) — lets you water 3 tiles at once.
3. Silo (100g, 10 stone, 5 copper bars, 10 clay) — lets you collect hay from grass for winter animals.

2.7 Relationships

Every NPC in Pelican Town has a **heart rating** (0–10, or 0–14 for your future spouse). Give them gifts they like on their birthday for 3x relationship points.

- **Talking** gives a small boost.
- **Gifts they love** give the most — check the wiki or experiment.
- **Gifts they hate** lose hearts.
- **Cutscenes** trigger at certain heart levels. Some are missable if you don't enter the right area on the right day.

Marriage is possible with 6 bachelors and 6 bachelorettes. Reach 8

hearts, give them a bouquet, reach 10 hearts, then give them a Mermaid's Pendant.

Important: NPCs have schedules — they move around based on day, weather, and season. If you can't find someone, check their house, the saloon (evenings), or the wiki.

2.8 The Community Center

The central story goal. On Spring 5, you enter the run-down Community Center and find glowing golden scrolls — the Junimos. Repair the building by completing **bundles**: collect specific items (crops, fish, foraged goods, etc.) and place them on the scrolls.

- Completing a bundle rewards you with something useful (hearth upgrade, sprinkler, etc.).
- Completing all bundles in a room unlocks a major reward (e.g., the minecart network, greenhouse).
- Completing **all** bundles restores the Community Center and unlocks the endgame.

Alternative: Sell one crop bundle's worth of produce to JojaMart and buy a Joja membership. This turns every bundle into a cash payment (no item hunting). The cost totals ~140,000g. Doing so locks you out of the Community Center route permanently. Pick one on your first playthrough.

Bundle planning tip: Keep at least one of every crop, fish, and forage item you find. Put it in a chest and forget about it until you need it for a bundle.

2.9 Early Game Priorities

Your first spring, in rough order:

1. **Day 1–3:** Plant parsnips, buy more as soon as they sell. Buy the backpack upgrade.
2. **Day 5:** Enter the mines. Focus on reaching floor 5 for the elevator.
3. **Week 2:** Upgrade your backpack and watering can. Save 45 salmonberries on Spring 15–18 for infinite early energy.
4. **Week 3:** Upgrade the pickaxe or axe to copper. Push to floor 40+ in the mines.
5. **Week 4:** Make Quality Sprinklers your goal before Summer. Plant at least one of each seasonal crop for the Community Center.
6. **Summer 1:** Massively expand your farm using sprinklers. Blueberries are the best summer crop.

2.10 Seasons and Planning

The year runs Spring → Summer → Fall → Winter. Each season lasts 28 days.

- **Winter:** Crops don't grow outdoors. Use this time for mining, fishing, socialising, and upgrading tools. Foraging in winter (winter roots, yams, crystal fruit) is still profitable.
- **Seasonal prep:** On the 28th of any season, clear your fields. Dead crops don't need to be cleared — they vanish on the 1st.
- **Festivals** happen each season. They're optional but offer unique items and relationship opportunities.

2.11 Next Steps

Once you have a comfortable feel for the basics, you are ready to move from **Wave 1** (enhanced vanilla) to **Wave 2** (content expansion). See [01-setup.md](#) for the full wave structure. Start with the Wave 2 graphics catalog sections in [03-mod-catalog/](#), then work through world expansion, new items, NPCs, and audio. Once those feel natural, [04-modded-gameplay.md](#) teaches the new mechanics each Wave 2 mod category introduces — and eventually Wave 3's gameplay overhauls.

3 Foundations

Prerequisite mods that other mods depend on. These must be installed first and load at the top of your mod list.

Mod	Purpose	Download	Required By
SMAPI	Mod loader for Stardew Valley	NexusMods	Everything
Content Patcher	Content framework for asset replacements	NexusMods	Most content mods
Content Patcher Animations	Animation support for CP	NexusMods	Animated content
Expanded Preconditions Utility	Advanced condition checking	NexusMods	Some content mods
SpaceCore	Core framework for many mods	NexusMods	Multiple mods

Mod	Purpose	Download	Required By
Json Assets	Custom item, fruit, and object framework	NexusMods	Many item mods
Farm Type Manager	Custom farm type / spawning framework	NexusMods	Custom farm maps
Extra Map Layers	Custom map layer framework	NexusMods	Map-expanding mods
Custom Music	Custom music playback	NexusMods	Music mods
SAAT	Audio API and toolkit	NexusMods	Audio mods
Alternative Textures	Texture replacement framework	NexusMods	Some graphics mods
Console Commands	In-game console for debugging	Bundled with SMAPI	SMAPI utility
Error Handler	Friendly SMAPI error messages	Bundled with SMAPI	SMAPI utility

3.1 Load Order

Place the == **Foundations** == separator at the very top of MO2's left pane. These mods should always load before any other mod.

3.2 Notes

- Always install the latest SMAPI version compatible with SDV 1.6.15.
- When in doubt about a dependency, check the mod's Nexus description — most list their requirements clearly.
- Keep foundations up to date first before updating dependent mods.

4 Bugfixes

TODO: Write this section.

5 UI and HUD

TODO: Write this section.

6 Graphics Base

TODO: Write this section.

7 Graphics Portraits

TODO: Write this section.

8 Graphics Terrain

TODO: Write this section.

9 Graphics Animals

TODO: Write this section.

10 World Expansion

TODO: Write this section.

11 Monsters and Combat

TODO: Write this section.

12 Items and Weapons

TODO: Write this section.

13 NPC Interactions

TODO: Write this section.

14 Grownup Town

TODO: Write this section.

15 Gameplay Tweaks

TODO: Write this section.

16 Skills and Professions

TODO: Write this section.

17 Farming and Making

TODO: Write this section.

18 Music and Audio

TODO: Write this section.

19 04 — Modded Gameplay: What Changes and How to Play

This chapter covers the new mechanics, systems, and content added by the modlist across Waves 2 and 3. Each section assumes you have already installed the corresponding mod catalog categories and understand the vanilla mechanics from [02-vanilla-primer.md](#). If something here references a mod you haven't installed yet, jump back to that category in [03-mod-catalog/](#) first.

19.1 Wave 2 — Content Expansion

Wave 2 adds new things to discover, explore, and interact with. The core game loop (farm → mine → craft → build relationships → repeat) stays the same — there's just more of everything.

19.1.1 Graphics Overhaul (Categories 03–06)

Graphics mods don't change gameplay, but they change how you see the game. The visual overhaul spans four categories:

- **03 — Graphics Base:** Foundational texture replacements that set the art style for the entire world.
- **04 — Graphics Portraits:** Character portrait replacements that give every NPC a more expressive, detailed look.
- **05 — Graphics Terrain:** Map and terrain textures — grass, dirt, water, paths, trees. This is the biggest visual change.
- **06 — Graphics Animals:** Farm animals, pets, wildlife, and monsters get visual upgrades.

What to expect: The game looks significantly different from vanilla screenshots you may have seen. Colors may be warmer or more saturated, character expressions may feel more personal, and some locations may look unfamiliar at first. Walk around Pelican Town on Day 1 to re-orient yourself — everything is in the same place, it just looks different.

Performance note: Graphics mods are the heaviest category on GPU memory, especially at 4K. If your framerate drops or load times spike, reduce your resolution or selectively disable terrain textures first (they have the largest impact). See [performance/03-mod-impact.md](#) for benchmarks.

19.1.2 World Expansion (Category 07)

New areas, villages, and locations are added to the map. These may be accessible through previously blocked-off paths, new NPC events, or transport systems you unlock through gameplay.

What to expect:

- New areas often introduce **new NPCs** with their own schedules, heart events, and gift preferences. Treat them like any other villager — talk to them, give gifts, watch for heart events.
- Some expanded areas have **new shops** selling unique items. Check these regularly.
- Expanded areas may add **new forage spots, fishing locations, and mining nodes**. Re-explore old routes — the new content is often tucked into places you stopped visiting.
- **Time investment:** Exploring every new area can take an in-game season. Don't rush. The content isn't going anywhere.

Key mechanic: Several expansion mods gate areas behind **Community Center progress, heart levels, or seasonal events**. If an area seems inaccessible, you probably haven't met the unlock condition. Keep playing.

19.1.3 Monsters and Combat (Category 08)

New enemy types appear in the mines, in expanded areas, and potentially on your farm (if using the Wilderness farm map). Combat difficulty scales up compared to vanilla.

What to expect:

- New monsters have **unique attack patterns** — don't assume the vanilla dodge-then-swing rhythm works on everything. Watch their telegraphs.
- Some monsters have **elemental resistances or weaknesses**. A sword that melted slimes in vanilla may bounce off a new enemy type. Experiment with weapon types.
- **Boss variants** of existing enemies may appear on deeper mine floors or in special encounters. These hit harder and have more health.
- New monster loot feeds into Wave 2's **Item and Weapons** category — what drops is often the key ingredient for new equipment.

Tips: - Bring more food than you think you need. New monsters hit harder. - Upgrade your weapon one tier earlier than you would in vanilla. - If a new enemy one-shots you, you're under-gearred. Go back to the previous tier, craft better equipment, and try again.

19.1.4 Items and Weapons (Category 09)

New weapons, rings, consumables, and crafting materials expand your combat and utility options. This category adds depth without breaking balance — nothing here is a cheat weapon.

What to expect:

- New **weapon types** may fill niches the vanilla sword/club/dagger trio doesn't cover.
- New **rings** stack with existing effects. You can wear two rings in vanilla; modded rings may unlock additional slots or combine effects.
- New **consumables** (elixirs, tonics, special foods) give temporary buffs beyond vanilla's food buffs. Buff stacking rules still apply — same-stat buffs overwrite, different stats stack.
- Some new items are **crafted from monster drops** introduced in Category 08. If you can't craft something, you need to hunt the monster that drops its component.

Tips: - Read item tooltips carefully — modded items often have effects that aren't obvious from their icon. - Sell nothing marked "crafting material" until you know what it builds. - The Adventurer's Guild may sell new weapons after you defeat certain new monster types.

19.1.5 NPC Interactions (Category 10)

Expanded dialogue, new heart events, and deeper character arcs for vanilla NPCs. Some mods in this category add entirely new NPCs with full storylines.

What to expect:

- Vanilla NPCs have **many more lines of dialogue**. Talking to them daily actually gives new conversations instead of repeats. This matters — you learn more about their personalities and backstories.
- **New heart events** trigger at levels that were previously empty in vanilla. Revisit familiar characters after reaching the next heart threshold.
- New NPCs follow the same rules as vanilla: **talk daily, give loved gifts, trigger heart events, repeat**. Their schedules vary by season and weather — use the same strategies you learned in the vanilla primer.
- Some mods add **platonic and romantic dialogue paths** that diverge based on your choices in heart events. Your responses matter.

Tips: - Don't skip dialogue just because you "know" the character from vanilla — the modded version may surprise you. - New NPCs have their own gift preferences. Experiment, or check the mod's documentation (not the vanilla wiki).

19.1.6 Grown-Up Town (Category 11)

Tasteful mature content — expanded dating dialogue, seasonal outfits, suggestive-but-tasteful event scenes, and relationship depth that acknowledges the player character as an adult.

What to expect:

- **Dating dialogue** is more mature and varied. Characters express attraction, vulnerability, and intimacy in ways vanilla only hints at.
- **Seasonal outfits** change how NPCs look throughout the year, adding visual variety to daily interactions.
- Some events have **mature themes** (implied intimacy, relationship milestones). Nothing is explicit or pornographic — the guide deliberately excludes that content.

Tips: - This content is optional. If a mod in this category makes you uncomfortable, disable it — nothing else depends on it. - Most mature content triggers at higher heart levels (6+ hearts), so it won't ambush a new player.

19.1.7 Music and Audio (Category 15)

New soundtrack tracks, ambient soundscapes, and audio enhancements that replace or supplement vanilla's music.

What to expect:

- **Location-specific music** may change. Familiar areas now have new themes.
- **Season-specific tracks** give each season a distinct sonic identity.
- **Event music** (festivals, heart events) may have new compositions.
- Some mods add **ambient sounds** (birds, wind, water) that play alongside music.

No new mechanics to learn — just listen and enjoy. If a track isn't to your taste, audio mods can be disabled individually without affecting anything else.

19.2 Wave 3 — Gameplay Overhaul

Wave 3 changes *how* the game plays. Skills work differently, professions have new paths, farming and crafting are expanded, and core balance is shifted. **Do not install Wave 3 mods before you've played extensively with Waves 1 and 2.** These mods assume you know vanilla's numbers well enough to appreciate what changed.

19.2.1 Gameplay Tweaks (Category 12)

Balance adjustments, quality-of-life features that go deeper than UI changes, and subtle mechanical reworks. This category walks the line between "enhancement" and "overhaul."

What to expect:

- **Economy rebalancing:** Crop sell prices, seed costs, and upgrade costs may shift. Don't rely on vanilla wiki numbers for profit calculations.
- **Tool and weapon balance:** Upgrades may have different costs, effects, or requirements. Check the mod documentation before spending resources.
- **Quality-of-life rules:** Some mods adjust how time passes indoors, how long buffs last, or how inventory stacks work. These feel subtle until you go back to vanilla and notice their absence.
- **New game rules:** Some tweaks add entirely new systems — mail-order delivery, crafting from storage chests, or season-specific bonuses.

Tips: - Read every mod's Nexus description before installing. Gameplay tweaks are the category where "I'll figure it out in-game" leads to frustration. - Test one tweak at a time if you're unsure. These mods rarely conflict, but their combined effect can shift game balance significantly.

19.2.2 Skills and Professions (Category 13)

Overhauled skill trees, new professions, and sometimes entirely new skills. This category fundamentally changes character progression.

What to expect:

- **Expanded skill trees:** Vanilla skills may extend past level 10, with additional profession choices at new thresholds.
- **New skills:** Entirely new skill categories (e.g., cooking, luck, archaeology) may be added alongside the five vanilla skills. These level up through their own activities.
- **Profession reworks:** Vanilla profession choices may be rebalanced, replaced, or supplemented with new options. Don't pick a profession on autopilot — read the new options carefully.
- **Prestige systems:** Some mods add a “prestige” mechanic — after maxing a skill, you can reset it for permanent bonuses and start again.

Tips: - Skill overhauls are the most complex category in the modlist. Before installing, read the mod's documentation thoroughly. - New skills interact with other Wave 3 mods. A “cooking” skill, for example, ties directly into Farming and Making (Category 14) mods. - Profession choices in overhauled systems are often **permanent** — there's no Statue of Uncertainty for modded professions. Choose deliberately.

19.2.3 Farming and Making (Category 14)

Expanded crafting recipes, new cooking systems, additional crops and artisan goods, and deeper farming mechanics.

What to expect:

- **New crops** across all seasons with unique growth times, profit curves, and processing options. Don't assume vanilla's “blueberries in summer, cranberries in fall” shorthand still applies.
- **Expanded artisan production:** New machines (distillers, smokers, dryers) process goods in ways vanilla doesn't. Each has its own input/output rules.
- **New cooking recipes** that use modded ingredients from new crops and expanded foraging.
- **Crafting expansions:** New craftable machines, decorative items, and utility objects.
- **Animal products** may have new processing paths (artisan cheeses beyond cheese, flavored honeys, specialty wools).

Tips: - This category adds the most items to learn. Keep a chest labeled “New Stuff” and dump anything unfamiliar into it until you understand its use. - Processing chains can be longer than vanilla's “fruit → keg → wine.” Plan your layout with room for intermediate machines. - New crops may

have **soil or season requirements** vanilla crops don't. Read seed descriptions.

19.3 Wave Progression Checklist

Use this as a rough guide for when to move between waves. There is no strict timer — play at your own pace.

Milestone	Wave Status
Installed SMAPI and MO2, Foundations mods active	Ready for Wave 1
Reached Summer Year 1, comfortable with all five vanilla skills	Wave 1 is working
Completed at least 2 Community Center rooms	You know vanilla well enough
Reached Year 2, finished the Community Center	Ready for Wave 2
Explored all Wave 2 expansion areas	Wave 2 is working
Maxed vanilla skills (level 10 in all five)	You know the game deeply
Killed every new monster type from Category 08	Combat is comfortable
Seen new NPC heart events through at least 8 hearts	Relationships are familiar
Completed the Community Center or Joja route on a Wave 2 save	Ready for Wave 3

Important: Wave 3 mods may require a new save. Many skill and profession overhauls don't apply cleanly to existing saves — check each mod's documentation for save-compatibility notes.

19.4 Next Steps

With the mechanics understood, the final chapter [05-mo2-separators.md](#) covers MO2 separator configuration — colors, gradients, and the recommended separator list that matches this guide's category structure.

20 MO2 Separators

Mod Organizer 2 separators keep your mod list organized and easy to

navigate. A clean separator structure makes it obvious where each mod belongs, simplifies troubleshooting, and helps you load mods in the correct order.

20.1 Creating a Separator

1. Right-click anywhere in the left pane of MO2
2. Select **Create separator...**
3. Enter the name and choose a color
4. Click **OK**

Drag mods into the separator after creating it.

20.2 Top-Level Separators

One separator per mod category, listed in load order (top to bottom in the left pane):

#	Separator Name	Color	Hex
0	Foundations	Black	#3B4048
1	Bugfixes	Red	#E06C75
2	UI and HUD	Orange	#D19A66
3	Graphics Base	Yellow	#E5C07B
4	Graphics Portraits	Lime	#98C379
5	Graphics Terrain	Green	#56B6C2
6	Graphics Animals	Teal	#3E8E9E
7	World Expansion	Blue	#61AFEF
8	Monsters and Combat	Purple	#C678DD
9	Items and Weapons	Magenta	#D55FDE
10	NPC Interactions	Pink	#E06B9B
11	Grownup Town	Maroon	#BE5046
12	Gameplay Tweaks	Cyan	#56B6C2
13	Skills and Professions	Sky	#7EC8E3
14	Farming and Making	Brown	#A0825A
15	Music and Audio	Slate	#7F848E

20.3 Tips

- Place separators at the top of their section in the left pane so all related mods sit below them.

- The load order (left pane) mirrors the priority order — lower plugins in the left pane win conflicts. Keep the separator order listed above.
- Right-click a separator and choose **Hide** to collapse its contents when not actively sorting.
- Use the **Filter** bar at the bottom of MO2 and type a separator name to jump straight to it.

20.4 Subcategory Separators

For mod categories with many entries (e.g., Graphics Terrain, NPC Interactions), you can add subcategory separators using a lighter version of the parent color (e.g., #86C7CF for a Terrain sub-separator).

Example within **Graphics Terrain**:

```
== Graphics Terrain ==      [full color]
-- Seasonal & Foliage --    [lighter shade]
-- Paths & Flooring --      [lighter shade]
-- Buildings --            [lighter shade]
```

Name subcategory separators with a double-dash prefix `--` so they visually nest under the parent.